

through a site, visitors' behaviour can be studied and patterns can be traced, which could assist in making the site more attractive and user-friendly.

Web analysers can use all the above fields (and several others which we haven't mentioned) to count the number of hits, unique visitors, repeated visits, user preferences, geographical location of requests, etc. And none of this needs to be done manually, counting each and every line in a server's log and finding similarities or differences. Software do all the counting that needs to be done, and even produce intricate charts and graphs to visually assist one in the understanding of the data so calculated.

However, it's not all a cakewalk. Several inaccuracies are possible, and Web sites would grossly misconstrue the behaviour of their target users if they considered the analysis of Web logs to be foolproof.

2.2.5 Statistics That Don't Stick

There are a lot of things that can't possibly be accurately calculated by any analysis program, even though commercially-available ones would sometimes have you believe otherwise.

1. Same IP address, different user

There is no way in which a Web site analyser can identify how many real people actually visited or requested a particular Web page. There are several possible reasons for this.

- Typically, ISPs assign a different IP address each time a user connects to the Internet. So it is quite possible that once you log off your ISP server, another user is assigned the same IP address that you were operating from and accesses the same Web site that you did. A Web server log would simply note that the request has come from the same source and consider that either the visitor is non-unique (the same visitor has been navigating through Web pages on the same site for a longer session).
- Online services (like AOL and MSN) often allow several hundred users to access the Internet through a relatively small number of gateways. Each gateway has its own IP address. Therefore, several individual PCs would be recorded in the log as a single client.
- Corporate users allow employees to connect to the Net through proxy servers. Each PC in the sub-network of the organisation